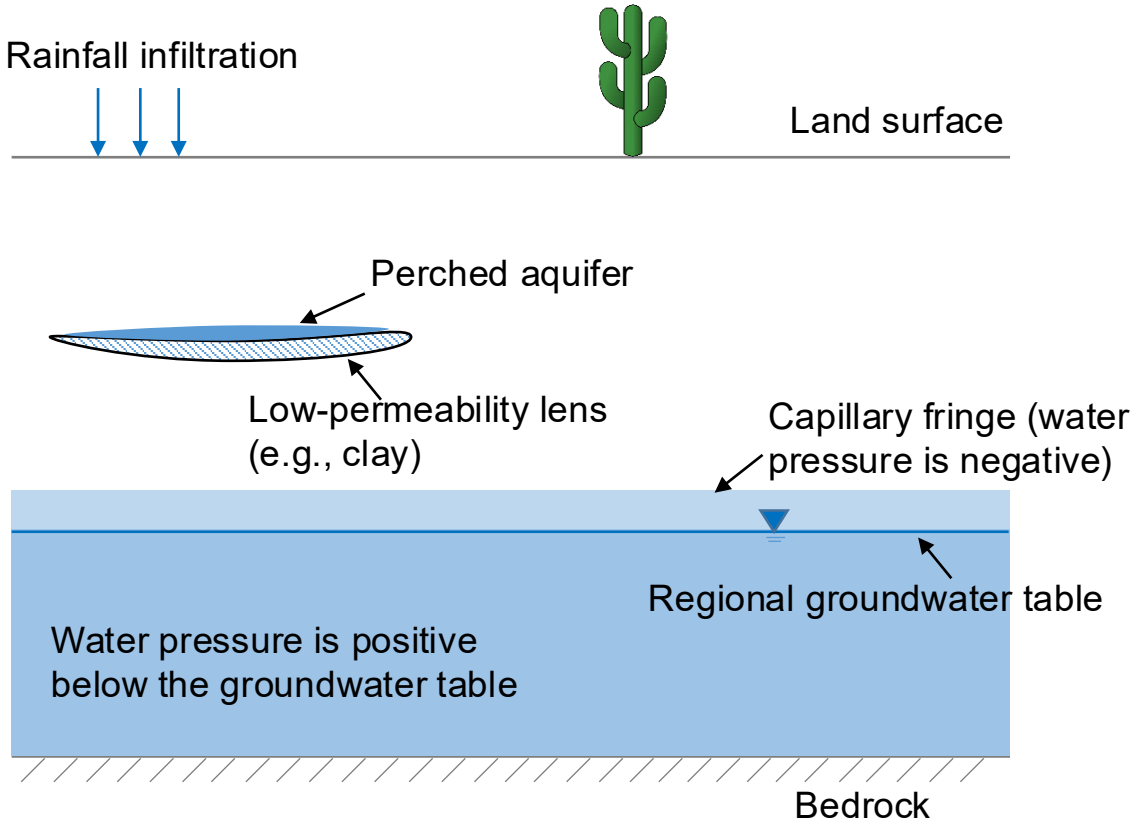
HWRS 561b: Physical Hydrogeology II

Solute transport (Part 1)

Agenda:

1. Overview of the course
2. Review: Steady-state saturated flow
3. Basic concepts for solute transport in saturated porous media

Vadose Zone: Conceptual picture



Vadose zone
(sometimes also referred to as **unsaturated zone**)

Critical zone

Plants
+
Vadose zone
+
Groundwater
(until bedrock)

VZ and CZ are both complex systems:

- Fluid flow processes
- Geomechanical processes
- Geochemical processes
- Microbial processes

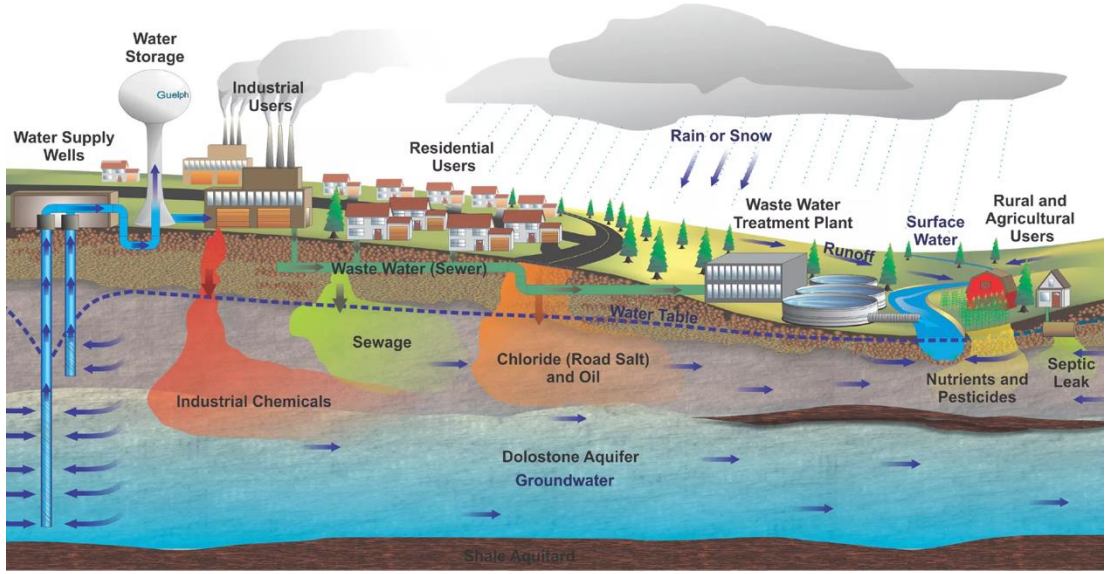
…

Vadose Zone: Context and who cares?

Agriculture and food production



Drinking water safety



Other examples?

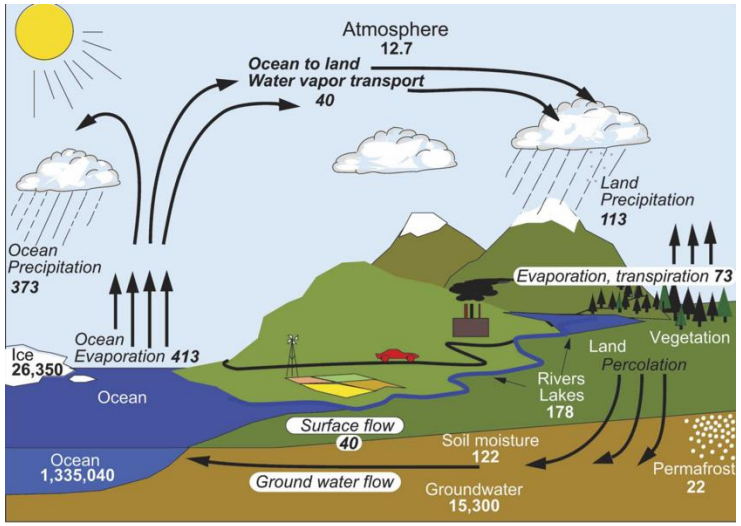
- Natural hazards management (flooding, landslide, and erosion)
- Infrastructure development (buildings, roads, bridges, …)
- …

Vadose zone processes can have profound societal impacts

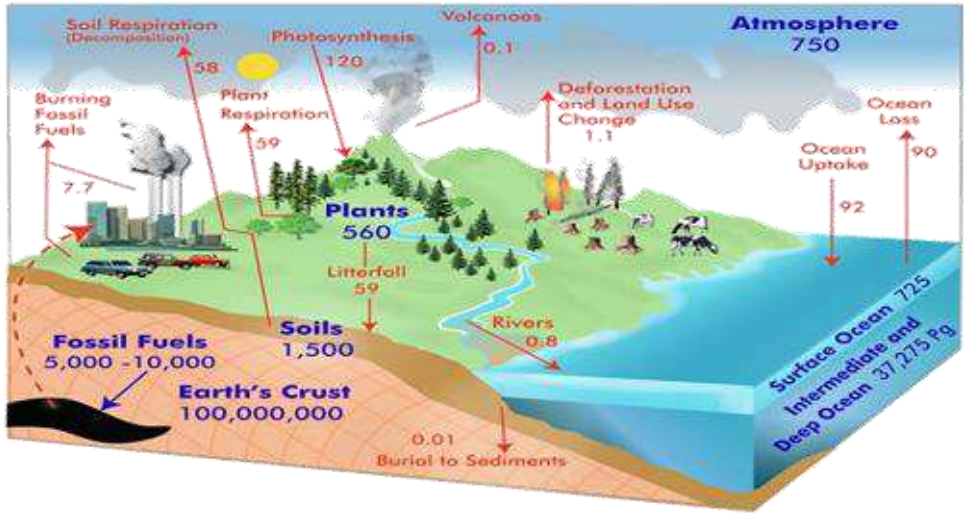
https://jooinn.com/agricultural-lands.html
https://g360group.org

Vadose Zone: Context and who cares?

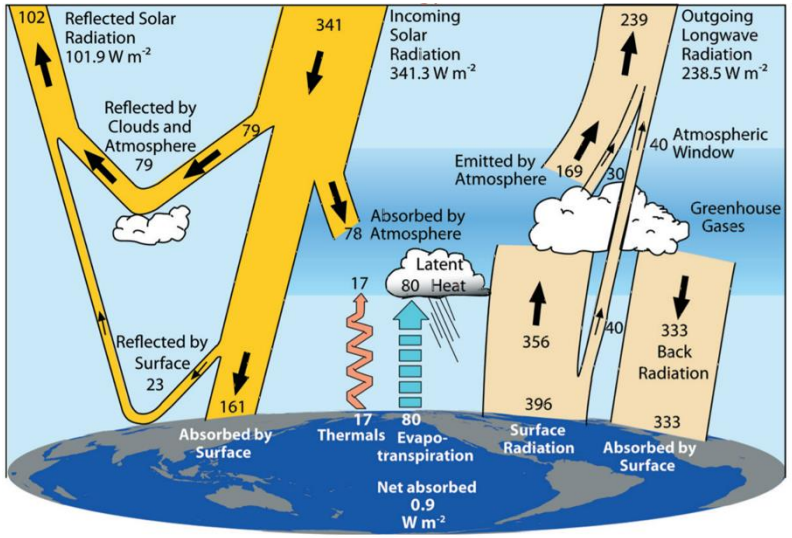
Hydrological cycle



Carbon cycle



Surface energy balance



Vadose zone processes play key roles in the global water, carbon, and energy balances

http://www.cgd.ucar.edu/cas/adai/papers/Trenberth_etal_JHM07.pdf
https://www.nasa.gov/topics/nasalife/features/globe-workshop.html
http://www.cgd.ucar.edu/staff/trenbert/trenberth.papers/BAMSmarTrenberth.pdf

Overall scope and approach

Scope

- Solute transport in saturated porous media.
- Flow and transport in the vadose zone.
- Practical applications: Pesticide, nutrient, PFAS

Approach:

- Conceptual pictures
- Physical laws and fundamental principles
- Mathematical formulations and analytical/numerical solutions
- Model vs. reality (measurements)

Philosophy:

Understanding first principles is more important than ever in an era where computational tools and artificial intelligence can obscure physical meaning. However, teaching first principles will not be effective if we focus solely on the first principles and conceptual understanding. Rather, it often requires an iterative process going from the high-level conceptual understanding to the detailed quantitative mathematical reasoning and then back again. Guided by this view, we will strike a balance between conceptual and quantitative understanding in this class.

There will be a strong emphasis on building intuition. Midterm exam is oral and will specifically test this. Final exam is written and will test your capacity to reason quantitatively.

Syllabus

Wk	Date (2027)	Topics covered	Homework dates*
1	Jan 13, 15	**First-week field trip; no classroom meeting**	
2	Jan 18	**Martin Luther King Jr. holiday; no classes**	
	Jan 20, 22	Conservative transport: pore scales, equations, BCs and dispersion	
3	Jan 25, 27, 29	Conservative transport: analytical solutions and breakthrough curves	Assign HW 1: Jan 25*
4	Feb 1	Non-conservative transport: retardation and adsorption	HW 1 due: Feb 4*
	Feb 3, 5	Non-conservative transport: analytical solutions and breakthrough curves	
5	Feb 8	Non-conservative transport: analytical solutions and breakthrough curves	Assign HW 2: Feb 8*
	Feb 10, 12	Pore-scale fluid distribution in capillary tubes	
6	Feb 15	Pore-scale fluid distribution in capillary tubes	HW 2 due: Feb 18*
	Feb 17, 19	Macroscopic description of air/water distribution	
7	Feb 22, 24	Macroscopic description of air/water distribution	Assign HW 3: Feb 22*
	Feb 26	Two-phase flow and Richards equation	
8	Mar 1	Two-phase flow and Richards equation	HW 3 due: Mar 4*
	Mar 3, 5	Steady-state 1D unsaturated flow	
Regular meetings: M/W/F 2:00–2:50 pm MST. *Homework and oral-midterm dates are tentative; HW due at 10 pm.			

Syllabus

Wk	Date (2027)	Topics covered	Homework dates*
9	Mar 8, 10, 12	**Spring break; no classes**	
10	Mar 15	Transient 1D unsaturated flow: scenarios	
	Mar 17	Midterm review and discussion	
	Mar 19	Oral midterm exam (tentative)	
11	Mar 22, 24	Transient flow: Green-Ampt and Philip models	Assign HW 4: Mar 22*
	Mar 26	Transient flow: numerical solutions of Richards equation	
12	Mar 29	HYDRUS-1D tutorial and preparation exercise	HW 4 due: Apr 1*
	Mar 31	In-class HYDRUS-1D exercise	
	Apr 2	Inverse modeling using HYDRUS-1D	
13	Apr 5	Inverse modeling using HYDRUS-1D	Assign HW 5: Apr 5*
	Apr 7	Unsaturated flow in multiple dimensions	
	Apr 9	Solute transport with unsaturated flow	
14	Apr 12, 14, 16	PFAS transport in the vadose zone	HW 5 due: Apr 15*
15	Apr 19, 21, 23	PFAS transport in the vadose zone	Assign HW 6: Apr 19*
16	Apr 26, 28, 30	PFAS transport in the vadose zone	HW 6 due: Apr 29*
17	May 3, 5	Course review	
	May 6	**Reading Day; no classes**	
	May 7	Final exam, 1:00–3:00 pm MST	

Regular meetings: M/W/F 2:00–2:50 pm MST. *Homework and oral-midterm dates are tentative; HW due at 10 pm.

Other course information

Readings (Scan copies will be provided)

- *Contaminant Hydrogeology* — C. W. Fetter, T. Boving, and D. Kreamer (2018)
- *Subsurface Hydrology* — G. F. Pinder and M. A. Celia (2006)
- *Soil Physics* — W. A. Jury and R. Horton (2004)

Grading:

Course assignments	45%
Projects – physical hydrogeology component	10%
Midterm exam (oral)	20%
Final exam (written)	20%
Participation	5%
Art of porous media flow submission	+5%

Class websites:

1. GitHub

- https://boguoporousmedia.github.io/HWRS561b-2027Spring/
- The **primary** site that we use for sharing lecture notes and scheduling.

2. D2L

- Reading materials and materials for homework and exams.
- Submit homework and exams.

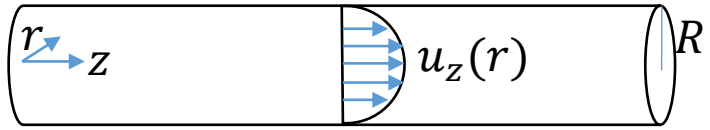
Saturated flow

$$\frac{D}{Dt} = \frac{\partial}{\partial t} + u_r\frac{\partial}{\partial r} + \frac{u_\theta}{r}\frac{\partial}{\partial \theta} + u_z\frac{\partial}{\partial z}$$

$$\nabla^2 = \frac{\partial^2}{\partial r^2} + \frac{1}{r}\frac{\partial}{\partial r} + \frac{1}{r^2}\frac{\partial^2}{\partial \theta^2} + \frac{\partial^2}{\partial z^2}$$

Permeability $[L^2]$

"Hagen-Poiseuille" flow



Navier-Stokes Equation

$$\rho\frac{Du_z}{Dt} = -\frac{\partial p}{\partial z} + f_z + \mu\nabla^2 u_z$$

($\frac{Du_z}{Dt} \to 0$: Steady state & low Reynolds #; $f_z \to 0$: Neglect body forces)

Note for the Laplacian: $\nabla^2 = \frac{\partial^2}{\partial r^2} + \frac{1}{r}\frac{\partial}{\partial r} = \frac{1}{r}\frac{\partial}{\partial r}\left(r\frac{\partial}{\partial r}\right)$

Notes for Darcy's Law:

$$q = -K\nabla H = -K\nabla\psi \qquad K = \frac{k\rho g}{\mu}$$

$$= -\frac{k\rho g}{\mu}\nabla\psi$$

$$p = \rho g\psi$$

$$= -\frac{k}{\mu}\nabla p$$

$$\Rightarrow \mu\frac{1}{r}\frac{\partial}{\partial r}\left(r\frac{\partial u_z}{\partial r}\right) = \frac{\partial p}{\partial z}$$

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial r}\left(r\frac{\partial u_z}{\partial r}\right) = \frac{r}{\mu}\frac{\partial p}{\partial z}$$

$$r\frac{\partial u_z}{\partial r} = \frac{r^2}{2\mu}\frac{\partial p}{\partial z} + C_1$$

$$\frac{\partial u_z}{\partial r} = \frac{r}{2\mu}\frac{\partial p}{\partial z} + \frac{1}{r}C_1$$

$$\Rightarrow u_z = \frac{r^2}{4\mu}\frac{\partial p}{\partial z} + C_1\ln r + C_2$$

BC:

$$\frac{\partial u_z}{\partial r}\Big|_{r=0} = 0 \Rightarrow C_1 = 0$$

$$u_z|_{r=R} = 0 \Rightarrow C_2 = -\frac{R^2}{4\mu}\frac{\partial p}{\partial z}$$

$$\Rightarrow u_z = \frac{1}{4\mu}\frac{\partial p}{\partial z}(r^2 - R^2)$$

$$Q = \int_0^R 2\pi r u_z\,\mathrm{d}r = \int_0^R \frac{\pi}{2\mu}\frac{\partial p}{\partial z}(r^3 - rR^2)\,\mathrm{d}r$$

Darcy's Law

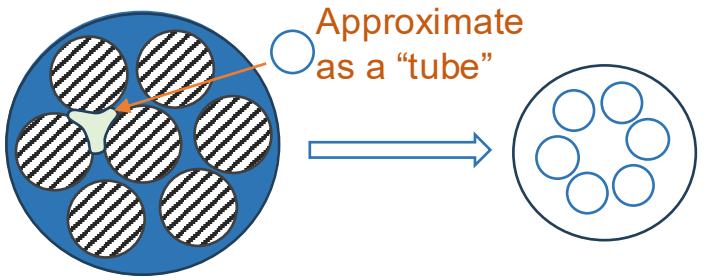
$$\Rightarrow q = \frac{Q}{A} = -\frac{R^2/8}{\mu}\frac{\partial p}{\partial z}$$

$$\Rightarrow k = R^2/8 \quad [L^2]$$

=> The permeability of the tube is $k = R^2/8$

Saturated flow

- Derivation of permeability for a tube based on the Hagen-Poiseuille flow (simplified N-S equation).
  - ✓ Permeability ~ R^2
  - ✓ The origin of Darcy's law is N-S equation
  - ✓ Permeability for a bundle of tubes of uniform size?



n tubes
k_{ST}
ϕ

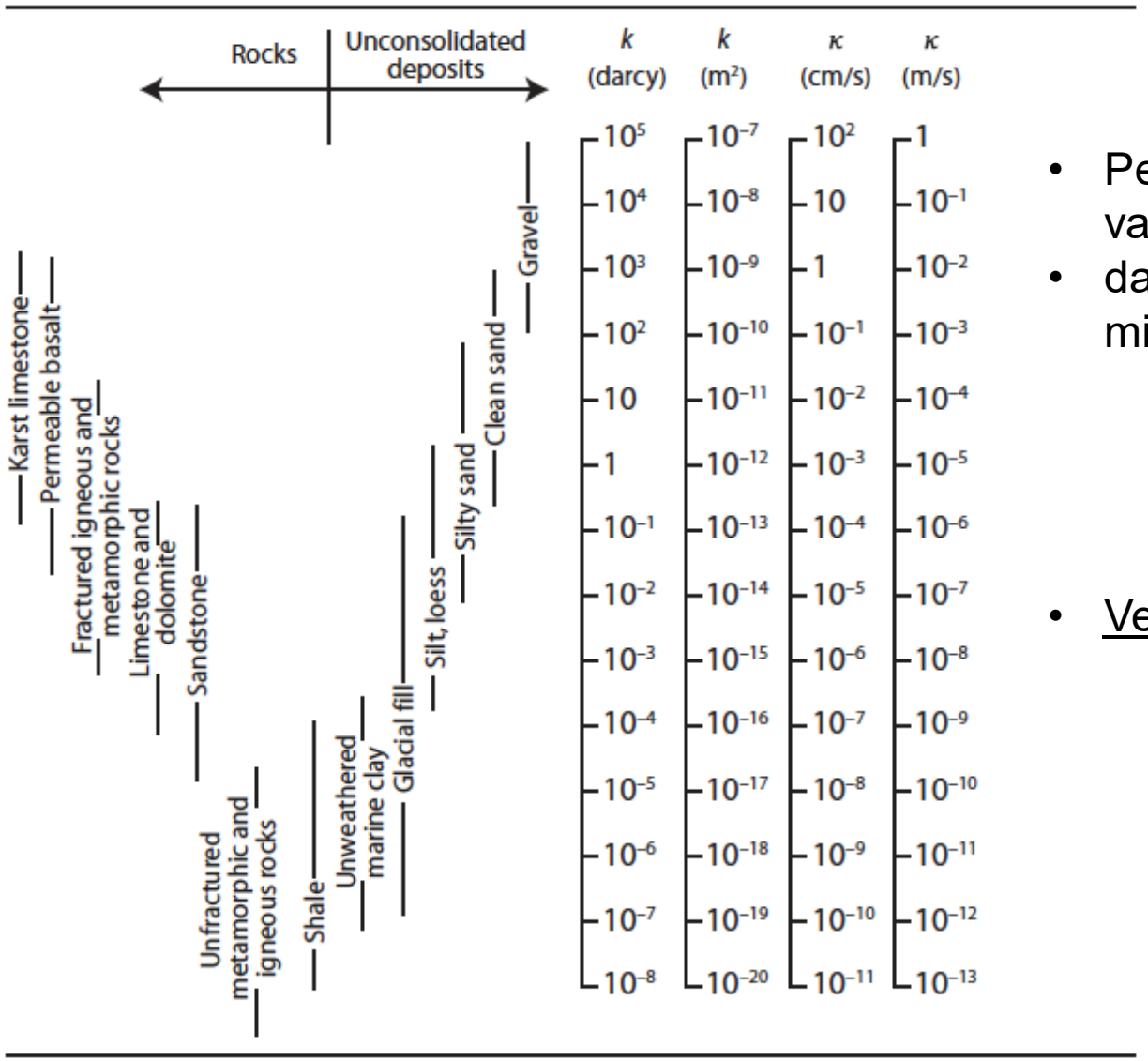
$$\bar{q} = \frac{nq\pi R^2}{n\pi R^2/\phi} = \phi q = -\phi \frac{k_{ST}}{\mu}\frac{\partial p}{\partial x}$$

$$\bar{q} = -\frac{k_{BoT}}{\mu}\frac{\partial p}{\partial x}$$

$$k_{BoT} = \phi k_{ST}$$

k_{ST} is the permeability for a single tube.

Saturated flow



- Permeability and conductivity values for various soil and rock media
- darcy (d) = $9.869233 \times 10^{-13}\ \mathrm{m}^2 \approx 1\ \mu\mathrm{m}^2$.
  millidarcy (md) = 0.001 darcy.

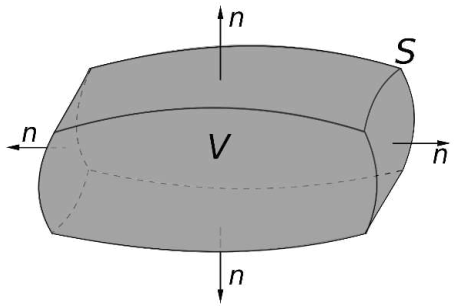
  A porous medium with a permeability of 1 darcy permits a flow of 1 cm³/s of a fluid with viscosity 1 cP (1 mPa·s) under a pressure gradient of 1 atm/cm acting across an area of 1 cm².

  9.869233=1/1.013250. 1 atm = 1.013250 x 10^5 Pa
- Velocity of groundwater flow $\sim 1\ \mathrm{m/day}$

(Freeze and Cherry, 1979)

Saturated flow

Derive the flow equation:

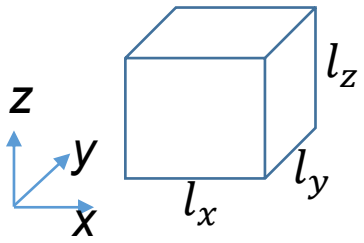


Recall: Divergence theorem

$$\int_{\partial\Omega} \boldsymbol{q} \cdot \boldsymbol{n}\, \mathrm{d}s = \int_{\Omega} \boldsymbol{\nabla} \cdot \boldsymbol{q}\, \mathrm{d}V$$

=> Divergence theorem converts a surface integral to a volume integral.

Mass conservation: Change of mass storage = mass in – mass out.



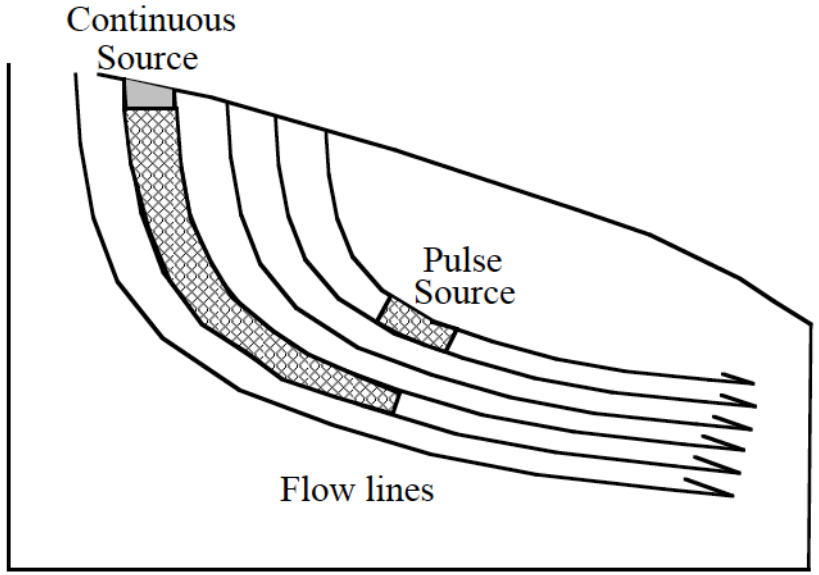
Rate of mass change:

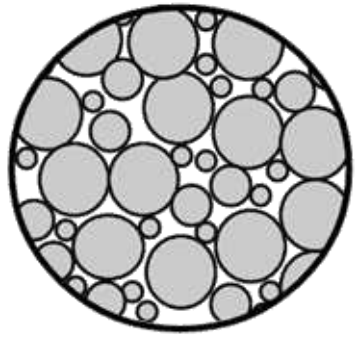
Net fluxes:

Saturated flow

Solute transport under saturated flow

Advection: The solute particles move along streamlines with a velocity equal to the groundwater velocity

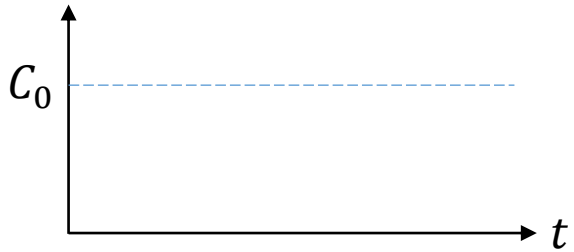




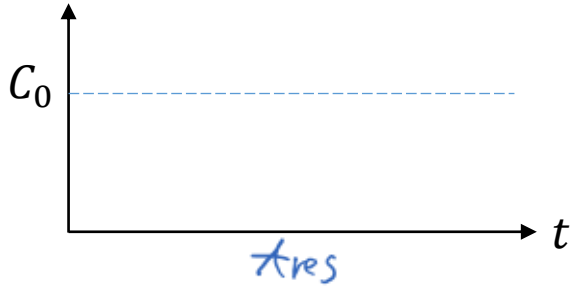
Porewater velocity is greater than the volumetric Darcy flux

Breakthrough curve (BTC)

Continuous source:



Pulse source:



Solute transport under saturated flow

Molecular diffusion: Solute particles move due to random molecular motion.

Free water: Recall Fick's Law

$$\boldsymbol{q}_c = -D_0 \boldsymbol{\nabla} \mathrm{C}.$$

Porous medium:

$$\boldsymbol{q}_c = -\phi D_d \boldsymbol{\nabla} \mathrm{C}.$$

$D_d = D_0 w$ is the effective diffusion coefficient, and w $(0 < w < 1)$ is the tortuosity factor. (Note: tortuosity vs. tortuosity factor)

Mechanical dispersion: Mixing at the Darcy scale (or even greater REV scales) due to local-scale variations in groundwater velocity

Q: Does mechanical dispersion cause mixing at the pore-scale?

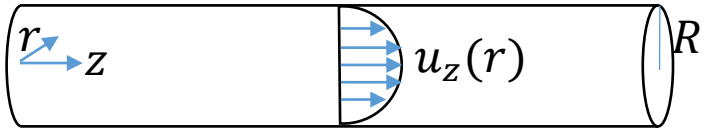
A: No.

Example: Dispersion in a capillary tube [G.I. Taylor (1953) and R. Aris (1956)]

Solute transport under saturated flow

Taylor-Aris Dispersion: Dispersion in a capillary tube [G.I. Taylor (1953) and R. Aris (1956)]

Solute transport in "Hagen-Poiseuille" flow



Governing equation for solute transport in the tube:

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial t} + 2u\left[1 - \left(\frac{r}{R}\right)^2\right]\frac{\partial C}{\partial x} - D_0\left(\frac{\partial^2 C}{\partial r^2} + \frac{1}{r}\frac{\partial C}{\partial r} + \frac{\partial^2 C}{\partial x^2}\right) = 0$$

Average ("Upscale") along the cross-section, and at sufficiently long times (derivation via the perturbation method), we obtain

$$\frac{\partial \bar{C}}{\partial t} + \bar{u}\frac{\partial \bar{C}}{\partial x} - D_L\frac{\partial^2 \bar{C}}{\partial x^2} = 0, \qquad D_L = D_0 + \frac{R^2\bar{u}^2}{48D_0}$$

$\bar{u}$: mean velocity in the tube.
$\bar{C}$: mean concentration in the tube.

$$\bar{C} = \frac{\int_0^{2\pi}\int_0^R C(r,x)\, r\, \mathrm{d}r\, \mathrm{d}\theta}{\int_0^{2\pi}\int_0^R r\, \mathrm{d}r\, \mathrm{d}\theta} = \frac{2}{R^2}\int_0^R C\, r\, \mathrm{d}r$$

Insights: The average solute concentration spreads out by a dispersion process (radial diffusion and axial advection) and follows Fickian diffusion. The effective diffusivity is not the molecular diffusivity D_0. Rather, it is D_0 + a quadratic function of the mean velocity.

Solute transport under saturated flow

Illustrative numerical simulations of Taylor-Aris dispersion (https://youtu.be/toC4RM_aUS4)

